



A medieval view of the city of Jerusalem, which was captured by the Babylonians in 597 BCE. It was taken again, and largely destroyed, 10 years later. After both sieges many of its inhabitants were deported to Babylon.

HAVING HELPED DESTROY THE ASSYRIAN EMPIRE, Nabopolassar (r. 626–605 BCE), first king of the **neo-Babylonian dynasty**, embellished the city of Babylon. His son Nebuchadnezzar (r. 605–562 BCE) defeated the Egyptians in 605 BCE, repaired Babylon's main ziggurat, and ordered the building of the famous "Hanging Gardens." The last neo-Babylonian king, **Nabonidus** (r. 556–539 BCE), moved his royal court to the Arabian oasis of Tema, but **discontent rose** among the Babylonians during his reign.

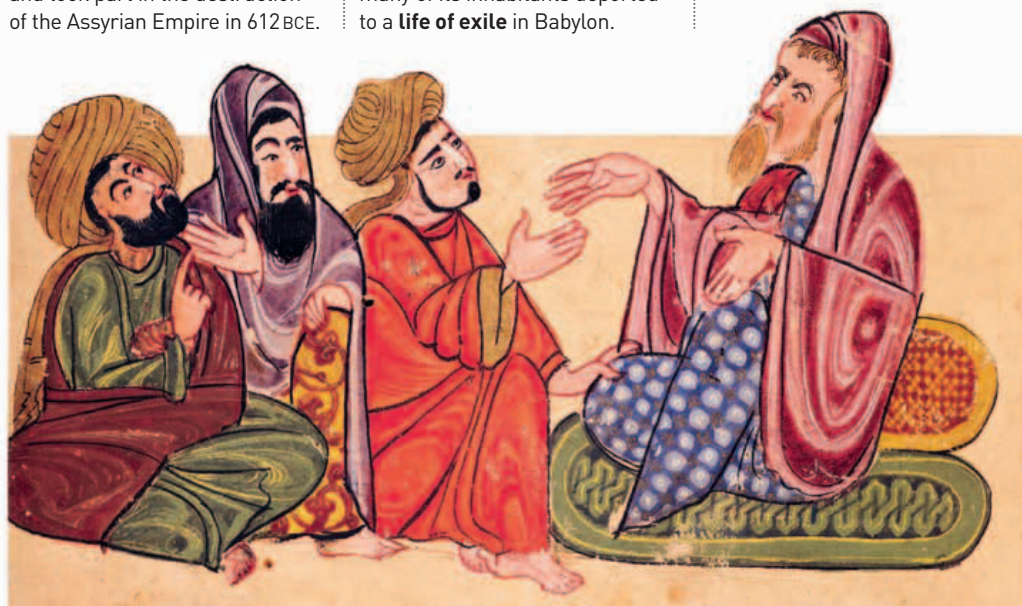
The Medes of northwest Persia (Iran), consolidated their kingdom under **Cyaxares** (r. 624–585 BCE) and took part in the destruction of the Assyrian Empire in 612 BCE.

Under the last Median king, Astyages (r. 584–549 BCE), Median armies campaigned in Azerbaijan and controlled land as far west as Lydia (Turkey). But by the 550s BCE, Media was under pressure from the Babylonians to the south and the new power of Persia.

The kingdom of Judah had long acted as a block to Assyrian and Babylonian expansion to the west. In **597 BCE**, Nebuchadnezzar **took Jerusalem** and deposed King Jehoiakim. The king they installed in his place, Zedekiah, turned against the Babylonians, and in **587 BCE** there was **another siege**. Much of the city was burned, the Jewish Temple destroyed, and many of its inhabitants deported to a **life of exile** in Babylon.

The powerful city-state of **Athens** experienced reforms under **Solon** about 600 BCE, notably a **law code** that protected the property rights of the poor, forbade debt-slavery, and moderated the more extreme parts of the **Draconian laws** (see 650–601). Around 560 BCE, Pisistratus seized power and began to rule as a **tyrant** (dictator). Driven out once, he returned in 547 BCE and established a stable regime.

The **Greek city** of Miletus saw the beginnings of **philosophical thought** from about 600 BCE. Thales (born c. 624 BCE) tried to understand the basic nature of the universe and thought its fundamental element was water.



Lawgiver and reformer

This image shows the Greek statesman and lawgiver Solon teaching. His reforms began to undermine the power of the aristocracy in Athens.

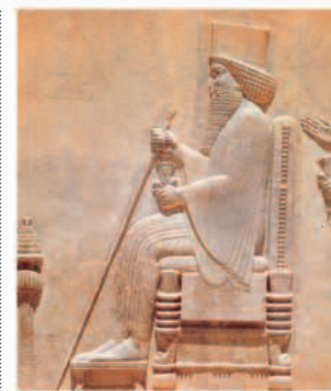


Central Asia became a stronghold of Buddhist beliefs. These cave paintings in Dunhuang, China, illustrate a variety of Buddhist parables.

CYRUS, RULER OF THE SMALL KINGDOM OF PERSIS (also called Pars) in the west of Persia (Iran), **revolted** against his Median overlords in **559 BCE**. By 550 BCE he had conquered the Median capital of Ecbatana and overthrown their ruler, King Astyages. Afraid of the **increasing power of Persia**, the Lydians under **King Croesus** opposed Cyrus, but he struck west and in 547 BCE, on the Halys River, defeated the Lydian army and annexed western Asia Minor.

In 539 BCE **Cyrus captured Babylon**, acquiring most of Mesopotamia and making the **Persian Empire** the greatest in the Middle East. **Cyrus died** in 530 BCE while fighting in what is today Turkmenistan, and was succeeded by his son **Cambyses**.

In 526 BCE Cambyses sent his **armies south into Egypt**. The Pharaoh Amasis had just died and his successor Psammetichus III



Darius the Great

King Darius is shown enthroned and bearing symbols of power in this frieze. His son Xerxes succeeded him.

Cambyses died in 522 BCE and after the brief rebellion of Bardiya, who was either the younger brother of Cambyses or someone impersonating him, **Darius**, a Persian noble, took over as king. Widespread revolts broke out, including in Media, but Darius put

“ I HAVE FOUGHT 19 BATTLES IN ONE YEAR... I HAVE WON THEM. ”

The Behistun inscription of **Darius**

was not well established. Cambyses defeated the Egyptian army at Pelusium in 525 BCE and then **captured the royal capital at Memphis**. He installed himself as the pharaoh and then subdued southern Egypt. Persian rule in Egypt lasted until 402 BCE.

them all down. He then **expanded the Persian Empire** by annexing lands in central Asia and on the borders of India from 519 to 515 BCE. In **India**, the political power had coalesced around the **Mahajanapadas**, a group of around 16 powerful

